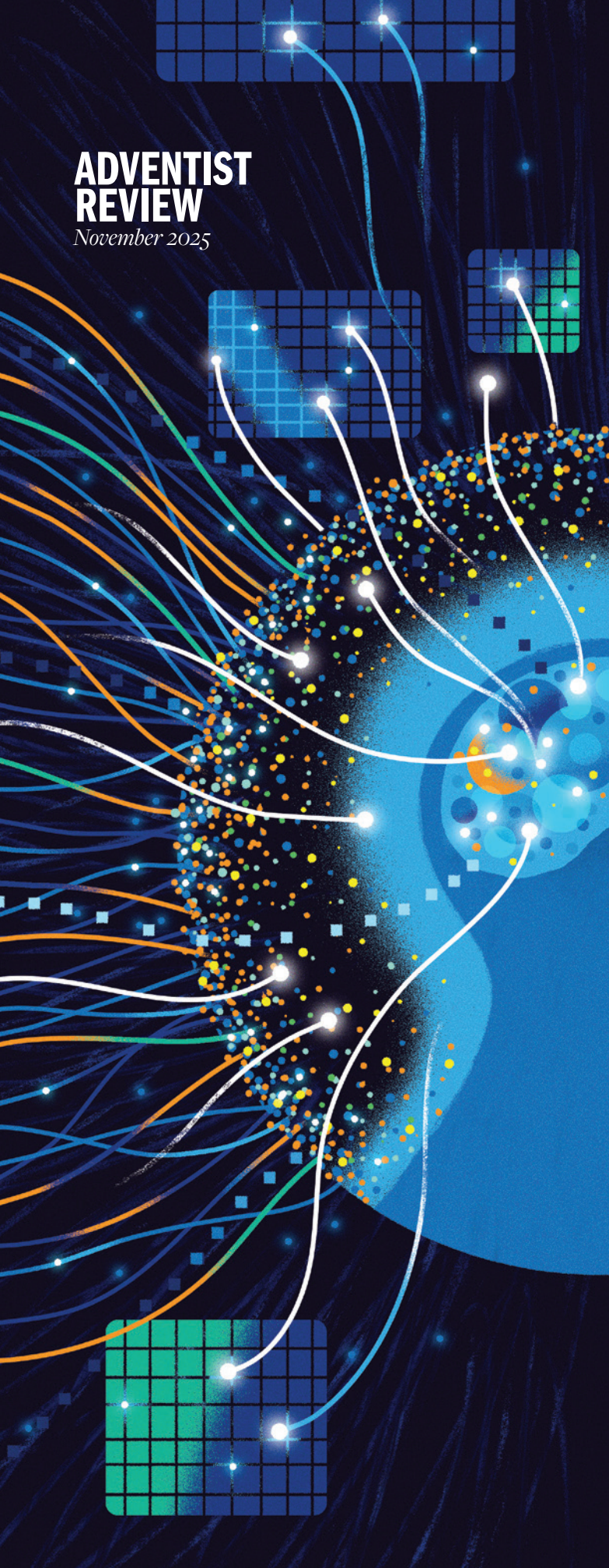


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FULL RESPONSIBILITY

The tyranny of digital, missional, and spiritual irresponsibility

JUSTIN KIM



Instructions:
There are 72 objects on the table that one can use on me as desired. Performance.
I am the object . . .

During this period I take full responsibility. Duration: 6 hours (8 p.m.–2 a.m.).”

For the record, this is not the type of art that I enjoy. But it sure did capture my attention when I read about it. In 1974 Marina Abramović, whose performances are often strange enough to raise suspicions of the occult, stood next to a table with 72 objects on it. For six hours the visiting audience could do anything to her body with them. The objects ranged from the innocuous feather, a rose, and grapes, to life-threatening items such as scissors, a scalpel, a gun, and a bullet. She completely absolved the audience of responsibility for anything that would

Thank God that in times when we have fallen short of our duties, we still have a God who takes on full responsibility.

happen to her, taking on full liability.

At first the actions were tame as her body was merely moved and tossed around. Three hours in, her clothes were torn. By the fourth, her skin saw blood as other uncouth acts were done to her. Toward the end, with a loaded gun pointed at her, the crowd quarreled on the ethics of taking her life. At six hours Marina stood up to end the act, and as she approached the audience, they fled the gallery. She in turn looked into a mirror, only to see a patch of hair that had turned white because of her mental trauma.

This piece of performance art was called *Rhythm 0*, part of a series of performances designed to convey the tyranny and domination of Communist rule (for Marina was from then-Serbian Yugoslavia). Some called it masochistic and others sensationalistic. But decades later people are still talking about it as one of the top 10 performance art pieces of all time.

Although shocking, scandalous, and lewd, the act reflects the worst of human behavior when personal responsibility and accountability are absolved. Though humanity is capable of so much evil, we Adventists aren't, are we?

We may not draw blood directly with our fingers, but our digital behavior, when masked with incognito handles, impersonal screen names, and the comforting distance that privacy provides, turns us into a mob capable of killing with our words in comments sections, direct messages on social media, and email replies. We live and kill under the mirage of irresponsibility.

We may not tear clothes directly with our hands, but our missional ignorance, when eclipsed by commercial interests, financial gain, and the comforting

distance that affluence provides, turns us into a mob capable of ignoring unreached souls with our Laodicean lukewarmness. We

forget and lose souls under the luxury of irresponsibility.

We may not partake in the uncouth, but our selfish natures, when duped that we are not responsible for our own actions, turns us into a mob capable of crucifying our Lord afresh, even with zeal, passion, and vehemence. We sin and die under the fervor of irresponsibility.

Scripture points elsewhere. We are responsible to each other (Rom. 12:20, 21; Matt. 22:39). We must be genuinely kind to each other, online or off (Col. 4:5, 6). We must pray for nonbelievers, evangelize, serve, love, and demonstrate to them Jesus, whether in countries afar or near (1 Tim. 2:1-4). And thank God, that in times when we have fallen short of these duties, we still have a God who takes on full responsibility, not for six hours, but for eternity. **✠**

* Frazer Ward, *No Innocent Bystanders: Performance Art and Audience* (University Press of New England, 2012), p. 119.

HUNDREDS OF HISPANIC ADVENTISTS FROM ACROSS EUROPE MEET IN BELGIUM

Spanish-speaking members are an important part of the church in Europe, leaders say.

Marcos Paseggi, *Adventist Review*



Attendees follow the worship service, during the 2025 Association of Hispanic Seventh-day Adventist Churches in Europe convention in Malle, Antwerp, Belgium, September 12. Photo: Marcos Paseggi, *Adventist Review*

Hundreds of Seventh-day Adventist church leaders, members, and special guests from across Europe traveled to northern Belgium for the 2025 Association of Hispanic Seventh-day Adventist Churches in Europe (AIALE) convention. The September 12-14 event, which took place at the Vormingscentrum in Malle, Antwerp, brought Adventist members living in several European countries for three days of worship, fellowship, and training under the theme “Mission Possible.”

An Important Part of the Regional Church

At the beginning of the September 12 event, David Carballo, a pastor in Belgium who was youth coordinator of AIALE and now has been elected the organization’s president, reminded participants that the growing association is a supporting ministry of the Inter-European Division. “We want to also become an official entity in the Trans-European Division in the near future,” he said, referencing the other major Adventist church region on the continent.

After Carballo, Yves Pierre, president of the Belgian-Luxembourg Conference of the Adventist Church, welcomed the 330 members who registered and the scores of guests at the event with a message in Spanish. “Spanish-speaking Adventists are a very important part of the church in this region,” he reminded them. “I hope this

convention may be a time to deepen your commitment to God, exchange experiences, and return with renewed momentum on behalf of the gospel message.”

“IT’S ALL ABOUT BEING LIVING TESTIMONIES AND WITNESSES FOR GOD,” HE SAID. “IT’S NOT ABOUT WORDS, BUT ABOUT PEOPLE WHO LIVE OUT THEIR FAITH.”

AIALE’s Ultimate Goal

Eliasib Sánchez Jiménez, outgoing president of AIALE, celebrated the efforts of those who traveled by air, train, bus, or cars to attend the convention. “Some of you have spent 17 hours on a bus to arrive here,” Sánchez Jiménez, a Mexican native who has served as a pastor and a leader in Spain for decades, acknowledged. “May God reward all your efforts to make AIALE stronger and more effective.”

He also reminded convention attendees about AIALE’s ultimate goal, which is “fulfilling God’s mission of preaching the gospel to those Hispanics that left their countries in search of a better life,” Sánchez Jiménez said. “That they may

not only find a better house, a better car, and more money, but that they may also find Jesus and live together with all of us for eternity.”

A Living Testimony

The September 12 opening program included moments of prayer and worship. The EMAD choral group traveled from Monterrey, Mexico, to share their worship songs and lead in congregational singing during the convention. Participants enjoyed singing together before listening to the opening devotional by Henry Barrios, an associate for Spanish-language Ministries in the Florida Conference in the United States.

In his message, Barrios called attendees to the 2025 AIALE convention to be part of “chain links of faith” to impact their families, churches, and communities. “It’s all about being living testimonies and witnesses for God,” he said. “It’s not about words, but about people who live out their faith.” He explained, “If we just talk, we’ll lack power, and people follow only when they see that there is power, the power of the gospel.”

Using the example of the young maidservant captive in Syria written about in 2 Kings 5, Barrios called every Hispanic Adventist in Europe to actively engage in mission. “It’s not our mission; it’s God’s mission,” he emphasized. “And God wants to use us because His mission is to save everyone.” **✝**

ADVENTISTS ADVOCATE FOR PROTECTING, HONORING THE ELDERLY ACROSS INTER-AMERICA

On enditnow day, church members promote respect, care, and a society free from abuse.



Libna Stevens, Inter-American Division News

Thousands of Seventh-day Adventists filled churches, city streets, and communities across the Inter-American Division (IAD) to advocate for an end to violence during this year's enditnow campaign, a global initiative mobilizing Adventists and community groups to speak out against abuse and promote nonviolence.

Sabbath services on August 23 highlighted the campaign's biblical mandate to "honor your father and your mother," with a special focus on elderly individuals, often overlooked, and the responsibility to treat them, as well as parents and guardians, with dignity and respect. That weekend, members marched through cities across Mexico, Central America, the Caribbean, Colombia, and Venezuela, carrying banners and posters denouncing violence in homes, public spaces, and elder-care facilities. Many also visited seniors, distributing food and care packages in homes and communities.

"For us in the Inter-American Division, enditnow reflects our commitment to promoting peace, dignity, and the safety of all people—children, women, and seniors," said Sandra Pinto, IAD Children and Adolescents and Women's Ministries director.

Rallying Against Violence, Honoring Seniors

Across The Bahamas, Cayman Islands, and Turks and Caicos Islands, hundreds of young people, women, and men rallied in community centers and along main streets to protect those who are vulnerable, particularly elderly individuals.

Concern for seniors was also highlighted in Colombia, where local church leaders addressed the growing problem of elder abuse. Celebrations honoring seniors took place across the country. In Venezuela, church members also took to the streets to raise awareness about violence against women, children, and seniors. More than 1,500 seniors were visited in their homes, while volunteers cleaned homes and nursing facilities and distributed food and care packages.

"IT IS TRULY INSPIRING TO SEE HOW OUR CHURCHES UNITE WITH A COMMON PURPOSE," PINTO SAID.

Regional Marches and Community Outreach

In Panama, Adventist churches honored seniors within congregations with special programs and gifted care packages on Sabbath.

Marchers, including Adventurer and Pathfinder clubs and Master Guides, as well as students from Adventist schools and hundreds of women, visited nursing homes, spent time with seniors, and engaged them in painting, crafts, and other interactive activities.

Similarly, in Mexico, churches focused on honoring seniors within their congregations, offering care packages, free medical services, health screenings, social visits,

and interactive programs. In El Salvador, church members participated in marches, community events, and meal distributions for seniors.

Raising Awareness and Advocacy

Women's Ministries leaders throughout the Caribbean Union Conference engaged in interactive sessions that equipped them with practical tools to confront domestic violence in their communities.

In the Dominican Republic, churches organized marches and public gatherings with expert-led discussions on preventing domestic and elder abuse. Workshops highlighted the importance of promoting respect, care, and reconciliation within families and communities, while reinforcing the church's role as a source of hope and advocacy.

Jamaica saw awareness efforts focused on protecting elderly individuals, often vulnerable to neglect, financial exploitation, and abuse. Lorraine Vernal, Jamaica Union Conference director of Women's, Children's, and Adolescents' Ministries, urged, "We must become advocates—watch out for the old people and help them wherever you can."

Reflecting on the enditnow activities across the region, Pinto expressed her joy at seeing so many actively participate. She highlighted how the church's united efforts to say no to violence are not only a stand for victims but also a commitment to protecting families, strengthening communities, and safeguarding the future. "It is truly inspiring to see how our churches unite with a common purpose," Pinto said. **✚**

“Dr. Shameerudeen, who is based in North America, is graciously supporting his former associate director, Pastor Nag, who is based in India, in taking the directorship role for the center. During Dr. Shameerudeen’s excellent leadership he developed a wide variety of ministry resources and expanded the reach of the center. His continued counsel as associate director will be invaluable.”

—Chanmin Chung, director of the Global Mission centers, about the leadership change at the Global Mission Center for South Asian Religions (CSAR). Clifmond Shameerudeen and Umesh Nag, formerly director and associate director, have switched roles. CSAR, one of six Global Mission centers, helps the Adventist Church to build better bridges of understanding with adherents of other religions and worldviews.

MORE THAN 200

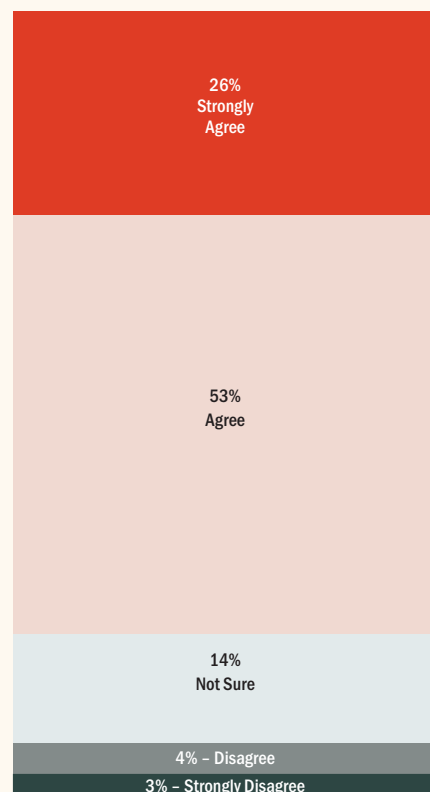
The number of students that gathered for a Public Campus Ministries evangelistic series on the campus of Agusan del Sur State College of Agriculture and Technology in southern Philippines September 1-6. The meetings came to life through the dedication of more than 50 Adventist students who invited their classmates and friends to attend. Heshbon Buscato, Southern Asia-Pacific Division Youth Ministries director, served as speaker for the series. His messages centered on hope, discipleship, and God’s plan for young people. The culmination on Saturday, September 6, brought inspiration to 24 students deciding for baptism.

“Our goal is to create a space where mission-driven creativity can flourish. The church is full of talented people who understand technology and ministry. Through this ideathon we want to see their ideas come to life—whether for inreach or outreach—so that technology can become an even stronger channel for mission.”

—Ryan Micua, Information Technology director for the Southern Asia-Pacific Division (SSD), about the first Mission-Tech event that will bring communication leaders, IT directors, and technology enthusiasts together to design innovative tools and strategies for church ministry. The initiative is SSD’s direct response to the global church’s Digital Strategy for Mission, an initiative that emphasizes harnessing digital technology as a means of connecting people with Jesus, supporting faith communities, and bridging the mission of the church to unreached territories.

HOW CARING ARE CHURCH MEMBERS?

In the Global Church Member Survey participants were asked if they believed that their fellow church members cared about them.



N = 145,655;
Source: 2022-2023 Global Church Member Survey

Data provided by the General Conference Office of Archives, Statistics, and Research

“This race was not just about one day of exercising—it reflected a constant process of preparation and commitment to integral health. Walking, learning to breathe properly, and maintaining a healthy diet are key to preventing such diseases as cancer and mental health disorders. The World Health Organization has recognized the Adventist Church as one of the global leaders in promoting health, and this initiative builds on that mission.”

—Cristian Beras, Health Ministries director of the Central Dominican Conference, about the Walk and Run for Hope 5K/10K race. The race took place on August 24 at the Mirador Sur Park, Santa Domingo. More than 500 runners and walkers of all ages joined this first-ever event, which brought together church members, leaders, and community residents to promote healthy living and wholistic well-being.

Photo: Central Dominican Conference



MORE THAN 1,550

The number of Adventist men that gathered in the Western Nigeria Union Conference for the fifth edition of the Adventist Men’s Organization convention August 6-10. During the course of four days, participants engaged in a wide range of seminars and workshops addressing health, family life, stewardship, entrepreneurship, and spiritual growth. Among them, they enjoyed presentations on common old age-related ailments, prostate cancer awareness, potentials in agribusiness, multiple streams of income, the beauty of needs in marriage, and sessions on daily prayer devotion and spiritual growth. At the close of the convention, participants renewed their commitment to mission, family, and spiritual growth.

60

The number of years that the Adventist Development and Relief Agency (ADRA) in Peru celebrated uninterrupted service in the country. More than 300 people attended the celebration held on September 2 and 3, which included the inauguration of its remodeled headquarters. The atmosphere was solemn and full of gratitude as leaders paid tribute to six decades of history, from the founding of Adventist Philanthropic and Social Assistance Work in 1965 to its official transition to ADRA Peru more than 20 years ago.

“I prayed and visited some villages around Korçë, where I serve as a pastor. God answered me clearly that we should focus on this village [Dishnicë]. There was no Christian presence there, so we saw it as an open door, because nothing is impossible for God.”

—Adriel Henke, local pastor and leader of the church planting project in Dishnicë, Albania. Five people were baptized in July on the shores of Pogradec, marking the firstfruits of the new Seventh-day Adventist Church plant in Dishnicë. Baptisms reflect more than two years of prayer, community outreach, and Bible studies. The project emerged after an ACTS training in 2022. ACTS is a support system for planters committed to multiplying Adventist churches worldwide.

ADVENTIST REVIEW NEWSLETTER

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30,000 ADVENTISTS MARCH AGAINST DIGITAL VIOLENCE IN BRAZIL'S MOST POPULOUS CITY

São Paulo leaders and members converge as part of the Breaking the Silence initiative.



Seventh-day Adventists from several cities across the state of São Paulo participated in the August 23 rally against digital violence. Photo: Thiago Spalato

Vanessa Moraes, South American Division, and *Adventist Review*

A massive rally of Seventh-day Adventists in São Paulo, Brazil, brought the Breaking the Silence initiative to the forefront on August 23. Approximately 30,000 church members and leaders marched through the central Avenida Paulista to highlight the risks of digital violence in contemporary society. Officially recognized by Public Act 17,186/2019, the initiative called attention to the current digital violence threat that affects children, teenagers, and adults, often with deep emotional consequences.

The rally began at the São Paulo Museum of Art and ended in front of the TV Gazeta building. Pathfinders, Adventurers, young people from the Caleb Mission initiative, Women in Mission representatives, and entire families participated in the march, as well as leaders and representatives of the eight administrative headquarters of the Adventist Church in the state of São Paulo. The Turma do Nosso Amiguinho, a group connected to a popular children's magazine published by the Adventist Church in Brazil, also made presentations along the route, organizers reported.

Ten platoons of marchers stood out along the route. Those who were on the sides distributed informative resources to passersby, while Pathfinders bands added rhythm and visibility to the march.

The march was covered live by Jovem Pan News, which expanded the reach of the initiative and added urgency and publicity to the issue, organizers said.

A Word From Participants

For Telma Brenha, Women's Ministries director in São Paulo and creator of the movement, the event was symbolic. "Breaking the Silence serves to raise awareness, educate, and prevent violence.

"IT IS VERY IMPORTANT TO RAISE AWARENESS AMONG THE CHILDREN THEMSELVES. I'VE NEVER SEEN ANOTHER CHURCH DO SOMETHING LIKE THIS. THE ADVENTIST CHURCH IS RIGHT TO GO OUT ON THE STREETS AND SHOW THIS KIND OF CONCERN FOR PEOPLE."

This year we raised the flag against digital violence in the heart of São Paulo. It's rewarding when I see the sparkle in the eyes of people with the same purpose. Next year we want to come back here to do even better," she said.

Among those who followed the demonstration, Bahian Larissa Santana, who has lived in São Paulo for two years, highlighted the relevance of the theme. "Today

it's impossible to know whom you are talking to on the internet. Parents are not always able to keep up with their children," Santana said. "It is very important to raise awareness among the children themselves. I've never seen another church do something like this. The Adventist Church is right to go out on the streets and show this kind of concern for people."

The march also included the testimony of those who have experienced digital violence. Pathfinder Isabella Carvalho, 12, told why she decided to participate in the action. "I was very sad about what happened to me, so I am here today to warn people that it's important to report it," she said.

For Jeanete Lima, South American Division director of Women's Ministries, the rally in São Paulo symbolizes the strength of the project on a continental scale. "Breaking the Silence is a pro-life project, which vouches for human dignity. Seeing thousands of people stopping at the heart of São Paulo was exciting. The Adventist Church was united to say no to violence and yes to life. I believe there were angels present here," Lima said.

At the end of the march, after a collective prayer, white helium balloons rose to the sky as a symbol of peace and awareness. The intention, said one of the organizers, was to "impact each person who was passing by at that moment," which raises the invitation to report and protect themselves. **21**

Outsourcing





In June 2025 Nataliya Kosmyna, a research scientist at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT) Media Lab, released early findings from a study that has raised some sobering concerns surrounding the use of artificial intelligence (AI). Her findings indicate that reliance on generative AI tools, such as ChatGPT, may be weakening core human cognitive skills such as memory, creativity, perseverance, and critical thinking.¹

Focused on young adults aged 18-39, the study asked participants to write several high school-level standardized testing essays. The 54 participants were divided into three groups and given different parameters for their essay writing. One group used ChatGPT to write their essays, another used Google's search engine as an aid, and the last group wrote their essays without any assistance. Using EEG to record the brain activity across the writers, the researchers found that of the three groups in the study, those using ChatGPT showed the lowest engagement, specifically reduced activity in areas tied to memory, creativity, and decision-making.

The essays written with ChatGPT were not only shorter and more formulaic than those of the other groups—they also showed less originality and a diminished personal voice. Over time the group using generative AI also developed new habits: rather than wrestling with ideas, they increasingly relied on copy-and-paste shortcuts to finish their work.

Nataliya Kosmyna, the study's lead author, pushed these findings into the public view early, before her study had been fully peer-reviewed, for one core reason: urgency. Alarmed by the risks to children, Kosmyna did not mince her words: "I am afraid that in six to eight months there will be some policymaker who decides, 'Let's do GPT kindergarten.' I think that would be absolutely bad and detrimental. Developing brains are at the highest risk."²

It is clear that what is at stake here is not just writing skills, but the architecture of thought itself—whether we actively train the mind to reason and discern or allow shortcuts to dull those capacities.

Thought

Who owns your thoughts now?

Daniel Bruneau

When Shortcuts Help

The right shortcuts, however, do not weaken our mental capacities. Instead, they allow the mind to remain agile, conserving effort for the moments that matter most. For example, neural shortcuts rooted in pattern recognition and procedural memory are the reason we can tie our shoes without thinking through each step or drive along a familiar road while also carrying on a conversation.

The problem is that unlike the natural shortcuts our brains create, the shortcuts aided by technology, such as AI, can begin to replace our critical thinking rather than enhance it. And because they reward us with the satisfaction of getting the task done quickly, we easily allow the replacement—trading thoughtful effort for convenience.

When Even Experts Falter

Not unique to essays handed over to generative AI, the field of medicine also offers a cautionary tale. Research has shown that doctors performing colonoscopies with AI-assisted tools detected

From the very beginning of human history Satan's method has been not brute force but subtle erosion of thought.

more precancerous polyps than those working without it.³ At first glance this seems like undeniable progress, and in many ways it absolutely is. But follow-up studies revealed something unsettling: when doctors later worked without AI, detection rates dropped. In other words, doctors' diagnostic edge, their ability to detect, had dulled. It is a phenomenon that researchers now call "de-skilling."

It begins to give rise to the fact that AI tools may sharpen performance in the short term, but overreliance erodes the very abilities it was meant to enhance. Anecdotally, most of us can recognize the same pattern in everyday life. For example, how quickly do we reach for a calculator when called upon to perform basic arithmetic, or how many phone numbers have we committed to memory since we were able to save contacts on our cell phones? Tools meant to assist can quietly hollow out the skills they replace.

Indeed, it leads to a searching question: If AI can dull the practiced eye of a physician, the very people trained to see what others cannot, how much more vulnerable are the rest of us when we allow algorithms to influence the way we think and make decisions each day?

Outsourcing Thought

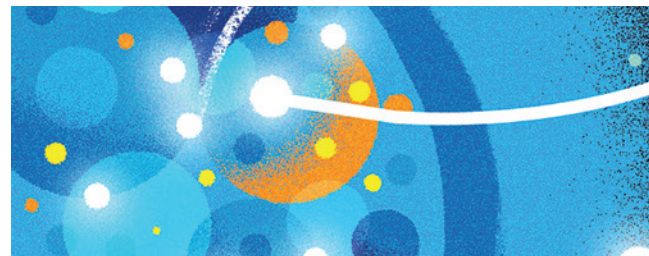
And perhaps this is where the deepest danger lies—when generative AI becomes a shortcut for thought, we are no longer simply outsourcing tasks but outsourcing the very act of thinking itself.

The implication is unsettling because this is not merely a technological shift. Rather it represents a profound surrender of the human mind's most essential work; its ability to engage, interpret, and choose, i.e., to think critically. Even more sobering is the reality that what we surrender in thought we eventually surrender in our relationship with God.

In other words, when we outsource thought, we outsource something deeper than productivity. We outsource what Scripture calls the heart.

In Hebrew, the word for heart (*lēb*) isn't limited to emotions. It is the seat of thinking, deciding, and discerning. "For as he thinks in his heart, so is he" (Prov. 23:7). The biblical heart is intellectual as much as it is emotional. It is the place where will, reason, and affection all converge.

This same thread runs into the New Testament with the Greek word *kardia* carrying forward the same meaning:



the heart as both mind and emotion, thought and desire. It is the very word Jesus invokes when He commands, "You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart, with all your soul, and with all your mind" (Matt. 22:37).

Put together, Scripture insists that to love God with all our heart and mind means entrusting every part of our thought life, including our reasoning, memory, imagination, and discernment, into His care, so that even the way we think reflects His truth and love. But to outsource our heart and mind to anything else, to surrender judgment, testing, and discernment to convenience or culture, is to abandon the very faculty God entrusts us to guard.

The Vulnerability of Suggestibility

Modern cognitive science confirms what Scripture has long warned. When we bypass critical thinking, we not only exercise our minds less but weaken its resilience and leave ourselves far more open to unwelcome influences. Psychologists describe this as the cognitive miser tendency, which basically means that when our brains conserve mental resources by defaulting to the path of least resistance, we become far more likely to accept ideas without testing them.⁴

But this is more than science—it is spiritual warfare. An uncritical, passive mind is never a neutral space; it becomes an open doorway. From the very beginning of human history Satan’s method has not been brute force but subtle erosion of thought. He dulls the mind through distortion, weaving in just enough ambiguity to unsettle conviction. Indeed, his opening move in Eden was deceptively simple, as he asked, “Has God indeed said . . . ?” (Gen. 3:1), a question designed not to bring clarity but to erode confidence and destabilize trust in truth itself.

And this is why outsourcing thought is perilous. It does not simply make us cognitively lazy but also leaves us vulnerable. The bottom line is that each time we hand

expressed in *anakainōsis*, conveys an unending renovation, a process that reshapes thought and character on a continual basis rather than a single moment of reset. And it culminates in *metamorphoō*, a transformation so profound it is nothing less than a change of our very self, as in the astonishing metamorphosis of a caterpillar into a butterfly.

In other words, Paul is describing a life-long training regimen, a discipline of mind in which discernment becomes fluent, truth becomes second nature, and resilience is forged one deliberate thought at a time.

This is why Ellen White urged believers to spend “a thoughtful hour each day” reflecting on the closing scenes of Christ’s life.⁵ Thoughtfulness here is not mere sentiment but the discipline of active,

And Scripture makes it clear that the heart and the mind are precious territory. They are the places where truth is tested, where trust is forged, and where love takes root (Prov. 4:23; Matt. 22:37; Rom. 12:2).

The Cost of Outsourcing Our Thoughts

It comes down to a question that is simple to ask but life-shaping to answer: To whom, or to what, are we entrusting our thoughts? Many of us give them to the noise of culture. Others place them in the hands of convenience, where even generative AI may promise efficiency but slowly erodes discernment. Yet Scripture offers us something far greater. It invites us to entrust our hearts and minds to the living God, who calls us to love Him fully with all our heart, soul, and mind and who renews our minds with fresh strength each day.

The answer to this question shapes not only what we do but who we are. It touches the core of our humanity, our capacity to think with clarity, to love with depth, to discern with wisdom, and to remain faithful when truth is tested. The danger is not only that we think less but that we surrender the very ground where love, trust, and faith take root. Yet into that danger comes hope. When we entrust our thoughts to God, He restores what was given away, renewing our minds and grounding us ever more deeply in His truth and love.

“Allow no one to be brains for you, allow no one to do your thinking, your investigating, and your praying. This is the instruction we need to take to heart today.”⁶ **B**

over the discipline of thinking to social media headlines, the noise of culture, or the convenience of generative AI, we loosen our hold on discernment and open the door to deception.

Renewing the Mind

It is against this backdrop that Paul’s words in Romans 12:2 land with startling urgency: “Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind.”

The danger, of course, is that this verse has become so familiar to us that we skim over it. We might frame it on a poster, perhaps pair it with a scenic background, and admire it as an ideal, yet fail to genuinely live it.

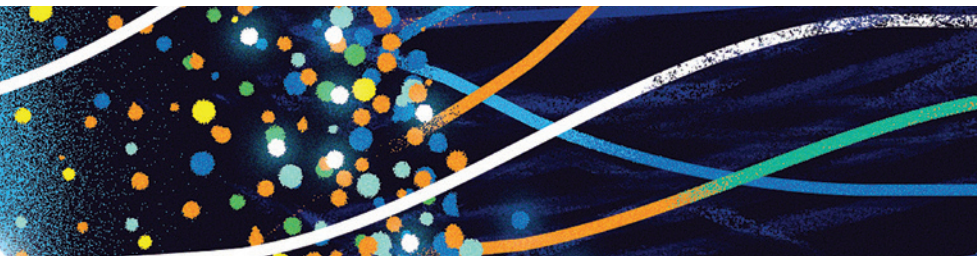
But Paul is not offering us a slogan. Rather, Paul is issuing a call to a continual, deliberate practice. In fact, the original Greek word for mind, *nous*, carries not only the sense of intellect but also judgment, perception, and conscience. From there the call deepens, for the *renewing* of that mind,

engaged thinking. Ultimately, when we wrestle with truth, turn it over in our minds, and allow it to reach our hearts, we become more discerning.

What’s at Stake

The findings of the MIT study point to something far deeper, to the way our minds are being shaped and reshaped today. At its core it reveals a crossroads for all of us. Will we be people who think, who stretch memory, creativity, perseverance, and critical thought, or will we allow those very muscles to atrophy in the name of convenience and efficiency?

The reality is that generative AI is not inherently corrupting. Like any tool, it can serve us wisely when kept in its proper place, sparking ideas, accelerating learning, and extending human capacity. But when it becomes a substitute for thinking itself, we are no longer merely outsourcing tasks; we are outsourcing the very heart of what makes us human.



¹ Andrew R. Chow, “ChatGPT’s May Be Eroding Critical Thinking Skills, According to a New MIT Study,” *Time*, June 23, 2025, retrieved from <https://time.com/7295195/ai-chatgpt-google-learning-school/>.

² *Ibid.*

³ “Artificial Intelligence-assisted Colonoscopy and the Risk of Physician Deskilling,” *The Lancet Gastroenterology and Hepatology* (2024), reported in *Time*: J. Ducharme, “AI May Be Making Doctors Worse at Diagnosing Cancer,” *Time*, retrieved from <https://time.com/7309274/ai-lancet-study-artificial-intelligence-colonoscopy-cancer-detection-medicine-deskilling/>.

⁴ Keith E. Stanovich, “The Cognitive Miser: Ways to Avoid Thinking,” *What Intelligence Tests Miss: The Psychology of Rational Thought* (New Haven, Conn.: Yale University Press, 2009), pp. 70–85, ISBN 9780300123852, OCLC 216936066.

⁵ Ellen G. White, *The Desire of Ages* (Mountain View, Calif.: Pacific Press Pub. Assn., 1898, 1940), p. 83.

⁶ Ellen G. White, *Fundamentals of Christian Education* (Nashville: Southern Pub. Assn., 1923), p. 307.

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Friendship

Ten—that was my goal. I had just become a Seventh-day Adventist the year before when I was asked to join the team of a well-known evangelist for my very first evangelistic series. My prayer was simple: at least 10 people from the community, personally invited by me, would attend.

Two months in advance we began knocking on doors and inviting people. By the time the series began, I was studying the Bible with more than 13 individuals and following up with more than 30 others. In my mind, everything was perfectly on track.

When opening night came, 12 people I had personally invited walked through the doors. I was over the moon. The monthlong series was powerful, and I felt certain God was doing something incredible.

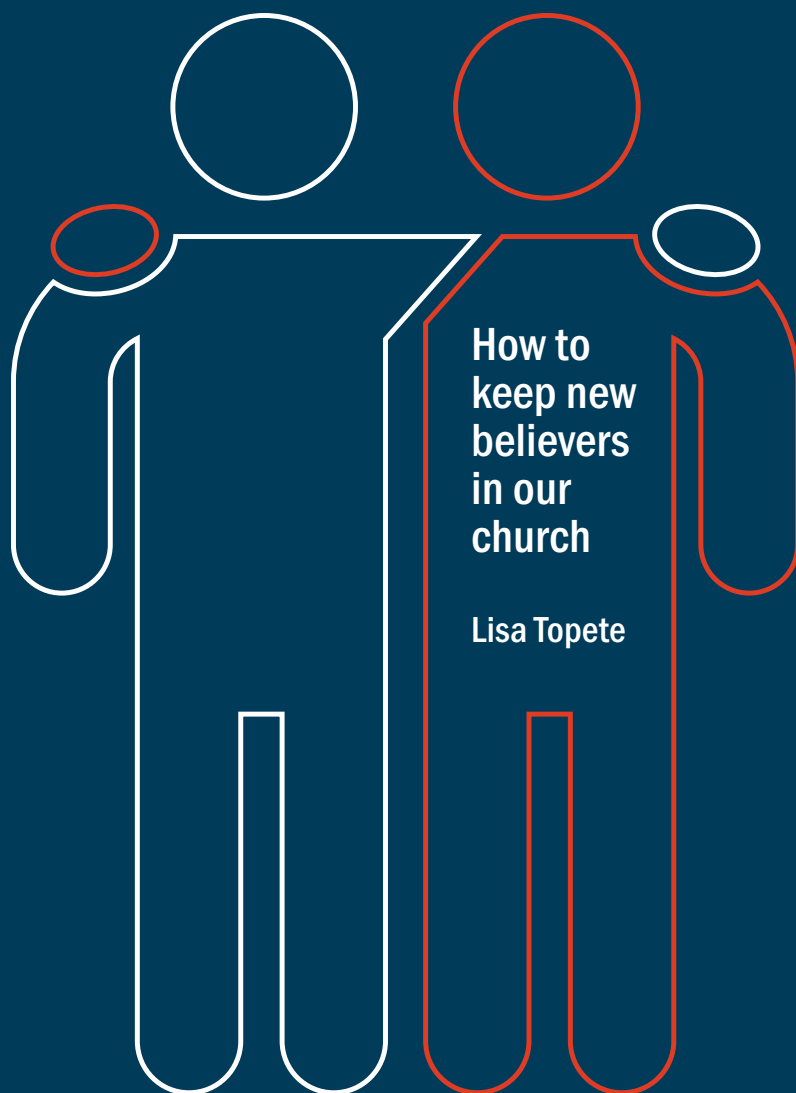
At the end of the seminar many were baptized, and once the evangelist left, we began the follow-up plan. This plan included continued weekly Bible studies and a new believers Sabbath School class. The lasting results? As sobering as this is to share, six months later each of the 12 had quietly slipped away; by the one-year mark, none of those baptized remained in the church.

What had gone wrong? Does this sound familiar?

I could not understand it. I felt defeated. After all, the preaching was strong, the message was solid, and \$20,000 had been invested in the campaign. Yet the outcome was devastating. This is not to discredit the method of using an evangelistic series—they have a place and a purpose—but something essential had been missing. Something had gone devastatingly wrong.

The truth is that this happens far too often. People come, they're baptized, and within a year they're gone.

In their book *What Every Pastor Should Know*, Gary McIntosh and Charles Arn highlight two striking statistics:



How to
keep new
believers
in our
church

Lisa Topete

Fuel

1. Eighty-two percent of new church members leave within the first year.
2. Most leave either around the six-month or 12-month mark.¹

Simply put, if a new member makes it through the six-month mark, they usually stay for one year. Then, whether consciously or subconsciously, there is a reassessment on whether they will remain in their current congregation at the one-year mark. If they make it past the first year, they are usually in it for the long haul.

The number-one question these new members ask themselves after six and 12 months is: “Have I made friends in this church?” The answer to *this* largely determined whether they stayed. The study further revealed that new members who develop about seven friendships during their first six months are much more likely to stay in the church, whereas those who form fewer than two friendships often leave.²

Adventist researcher Monte Sahlin echoed this reality, writing: “Three out of four [church members] leave for reasons having to do with their relationships with people . . . , while less than one in five leave because they no longer believe in some teaching of the church.”³

The problem, then, is not weak preaching or unclear doctrine. It is a lack of genuine friendship and community.

And that was the missing piece in my first evangelistic experience. The three angels’ messages being preached at that seminar were strong—they *are* strong. The relational community needed to sustain new believers, however, was simply not there. In other words, there had been no true friendships formed. They had no community in the church they found truth in.

STARTING AGAIN

Fast-forward three years later: I was helping establish a church plant as a church plant leader, alongside a team. The memory of that first series weighed heavily on me, and my mind was made up to do things differently. With determination in our hearts we set to work. We prayed, we worked. We worked, we prayed. But what would we do differently?

What God impressed on our hearts came straight from Acts 2:

“So continuing daily with one accord in the temple, and breaking bread from house to house, they ate their food with gladness and simplicity of heart, praising God and having favor with all the people. And the Lord added to the church daily those who were being saved” (verses 46, 47).

It seems the early church grew in a sort of sequence, and then pressed repeat, until the gospel had spread to the world:

1. The Holy Spirit was poured out (Acts 2:1-13).
2. The Word was preached (verses 14-36).
3. People responded in repentance and baptism (verses 37-41).
4. Disciples formed a Christ-centered community (verses 42-47).
5. The church experienced daily growth (verse 47).

We’ve seen the Spirit poured out. We’ve seen the Word faithfully preached. We’ve seen baptisms. What is often overlooked, however, is step 4: an authentic community.

Not just Sabbath morning fellowship. Not just a handshake at the door. Real, consistent, nurturing community—woven into daily life. This requires time, sacrifice, and a major adjustment of our everyday lives.

Church was never supposed to be something we “fit in” around our schedules. It is the foundation we are to build everything else around. That is how seriously we must take the Great Commission (Matt. 28:18-20) and the spreading of the everlasting gospel.

But without genuine friend-making through discipleship and community, the cycle breaks—and growth stalls. Remove “step 4” from the above sequence, and, logically, it follows that we will see a plateau in growth at the local church level.

CHURCH OF ACTS GROWTH



STEP ONE

Holy Spirit Poured Out

Acts 2:1-13



STEP TWO

The Word Is Preached

Acts 2:14-36



STEP THREE

Repentance and Baptisms

Acts 2:37-41



STEP FOUR

Discipleship and Community

Acts 2:42-47



STEP FIVE

Ongoing, Daily Growth

Acts 2:47

THE POWER OF FRIENDSHIP

Sociologists have found it takes about 50 hours to move from acquaintance to “casual friend,” and more than 200 hours to become “close friends.”⁴ Pew Research did a recent study that shared, “One third of U.S. adults say they attend religious services in person at least once a month, including 25 percent who report going at least once a week.”⁵ So, being generous, if the average church service lasts one and a half to two hours, then attending every week adds up to about eight hours a

The problem is not weak preaching or unclear doctrine. It is a lack of genuine friendship and community.

month. At that rate, it would take more than two years to develop one close friendship.

This gives at least one major and solid explanation as to why so many churches plateau or even decline in growth.

As one theologian put it: “One sad aspect of modern life . . . is we tend to think of church as a single event each week, rather than an all-week, all-of-life reality. If we are in Christ, we are members of His body 24/7/365.”⁶

STORIES OF COMMUNITY

When our church plant began, we shifted our focus to the Acts sequence we had observed. Instead of rushing people toward baptism, we prioritized small groups and friendship. This was not an easy shift. I attest to this. But we built a community first—and baptisms naturally followed. Some after six months, some after three years, and some not yet to this day. But whether baptized or not, they remain our friends, because we decided we had to be in it for the long haul.

Jesus said, “Greater love has no one than this, than to lay down one’s life for his friends” (John 15:13). Jesus is our greatest example of what genuine friendship looks like. He modeled it through sacrifice, genuine commitment, and love, and this became the hallmark of the church plant.

The following are a few testimonies:

Jim’s story: We met at a cooking school; he continued to come to anything we invited him to. Later he shared that he had questions about the Bible, and we began studying. He came to everything we offered: small groups, church outings, church services, and even our outreach events. Jim became an active part of our community. He became our friend, and we became his friend. Jim, to this day, has not been baptized, but continues to learn. His story is not over.

Julie’s story: A coworker introduced me to her family. We studied the Bible together, yes—but we also hiked, shared meals, and lived life side by side. Within six months Julie, her husband, and their daughter were baptized. Ten years later they are still active church members.

Rini’s story: When we first met, she invited me to her home. She loved to cook, and over time we became close—studying, shopping, sharing meals, and attending small groups together. Before her baptism she found a family. In that family she found Jesus. Over time her fear and anxiety melted away. Three years later she was baptized and remains faithful to this day.

FROM THE INSIDE OUT

These stories were not the result of clever strategies or polished methods. It was like working from the inside out instead of the outside in. These stories are the fruit of love, friendship, and community—Jesus working through relationships. Ellen White summarized it beautifully: “Better than all the friendship of the world is the friendship of Christ’s redeemed.”⁷

It is not about abandoning age-old, time-tested methods such as the evangelistic series, health fairs, or cooking schools, but about nestling them inside a genuine, Christ-centered community, fueled by consistent connection and genuine relationship. This is where enduring results begin to happen.

So if you are looking to make a lasting impact in your community, the path is simple.

Pray for the power of the Holy Spirit. And then—make a friend. A close friend. Then press “repeat.” 

¹ G. L. McIntosh and C. Am, *What Every Pastor Should Know: 101 Indispensable Rules of Thumb for Leading Your Church* (Grand Rapids, Mich.: Baker Books, 2013).

² *Ibid.*

³ Monte Sahlin, *Why Do Adventists Quit Coming to Church?* (Lincoln, Neb.: Center for Creative Ministry, 1998).

⁴ <http://journals.sagepub.com/doi/abs/10.1177/0265407518761225>

⁵ Pew Research Center, “Religious Attendance and Congregational Involvement,” Feb. 26, 2025, <https://www.pewresearch.org/religion/2025/02/26/religious-attendance-and-congregational-involvement/>

⁶ D. Mathis, “Two Truths About the One Percent: How Important Is Corporate Worship?” *Desiring God*, Nov. 3, 2021, <https://www.desiringgod.org/articles/two-truths-about-the-one-percent>

⁷ Ellen G. White, *Christ’s Object Lessons* (Washington, D.C.: Review and Herald Pub. Assn., 1900, 1941), p. 374.

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DIVINE SADNESS AND THE FLOOD

How can we justify God's total destruction of the antediluvian world by a flood?

There is no need for us to justify God's decision to destroy the earth through a universal flood, because He was careful enough to justify this most dramatic decision in the biblical text itself. We should look at the human condition and at God's reaction to it.

Increasing Corruption

After the Fall, the biblical text informs us about the damaging effect of sin in the human heart. The relationship between God and humans was permanently damaged, and humans themselves existed in a state of alienation from each other. Perhaps worse, a brother took the life of his brother, and the human race entered a process of radical spiritual differentiation. Humanity split up into those who served the Lord (the descendants of Seth) and those who abandoned God (the descendants of Cain). At the beginning of the Flood narrative (Gen. 6:1-4) the sons of God, the descendants of Seth, have been marrying the descendants of Cain, plunging the two groups into an unimaginable depth of moral, spiritual, and social corruption.

Corruptions of Humans and the Earth

The text shares with us God's perception of the problem: He saw that "the wickedness of mankind was great on the earth" (Gen. 6:5, NASB). The evil nested in the human heart was unquantifiable. There was something evil and deeply wrong with humans. "Wickedness" (*ra'ah*) does not refer to specific sins but to a state or condition that has totally invaded the

inner being of humans to the point that every dimension of human rationality—as well as of the will (the heart)—was "continually" (literally, "every day") inclined or striving toward evil. This is describing total corruption. Human wickedness had an impact on the land, and consequently it "was corrupt [*shakhat*, be ruined] . . . and filled with violence" (verse 11). The cause of this awful condition is not the land itself, but the corruption and violence of humans and animals (verses 13, 17). They are characterized by a corrupt way of life (verse 12).

While in the human heart there was wickedness and violence, the heart of God is filled with sadness.

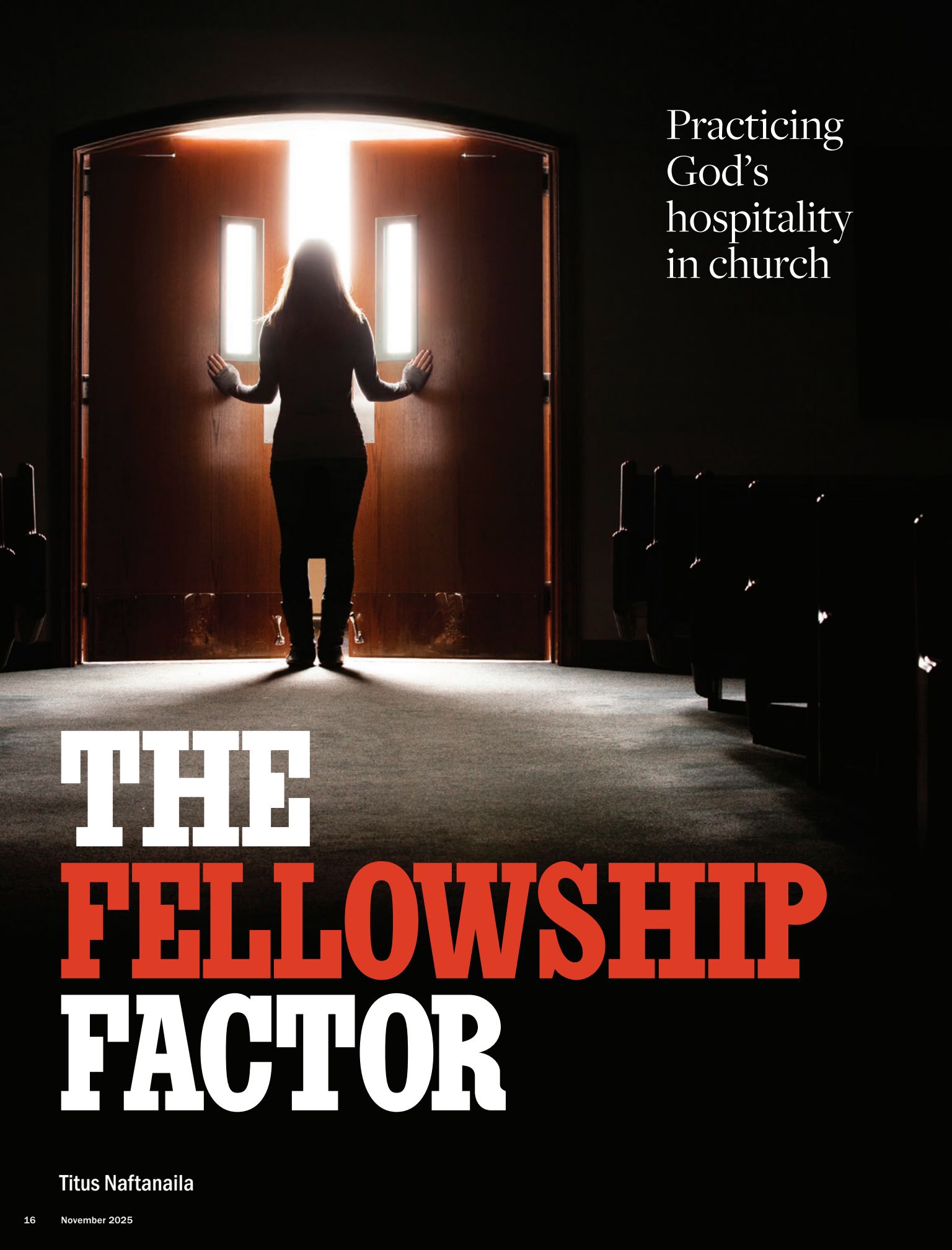
God's Reaction to Human Wickedness

God sees that humans have chosen their own course of action and not the one He intended for them. He "was sorry that He had made man on the earth" (verse 6). This debated phrase simply means that God experienced pain when looking at what happened to His creation, as it is immediately indicated: "He was grieved [*'atsab*, to be sad] in His heart." While in the human heart there was wickedness and violence,

the heart of God is filled with sadness. Observing humans and beasts violently destroying each other, the loving heart of God grieved. Love could not be indifferent to such savagery, so it intervenes. God will bring it to an end through a global flood. The self-destruction that humans are inflicting on themselves through wickedness and violence is finally implemented by God (verses 11-13; the verb *shakhat* means both "to become corrupt" and "to destroy"). Surprisingly, this decision is explicitly assigned in the text, not to God's loving wrath, but to God's suffering love.

Out of love God makes two additional decisions. First, His Spirit will "not strive" or "be close" (*yadon*), pleading with humans forever, but He will remain close to them for an additional 120 years (verse 3). Grace lingers. Second, life on the planet will not be annihilated. God's grace found Noah (verses 9, 18), who would become His instrument in the preservation of a remnant through whom God will bring into fruition His intention to save humanity, as recorded in Genesis 3:15. God committed Himself to preserve within the ark, not only humans beings, but also a remnant of "every living thing" (Gen. 6:19). A new beginning of grace will be dawning on our planet, pointing to the future arrival of the Sun of Righteousness, the Seed of the woman. ❧

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A person stands with their back to the camera in a dark church interior, facing a large, arched wooden double door. Their hands are pressed against the door frames. Bright light streams through the open doors, creating a strong silhouette of the person and illuminating the carpeted floor. To the right, rows of dark wooden pews are visible in the dim light.

Practicing
God's
hospitality
in church

THE FELLOWSHIP FACTOR

Titus Naftanaila



How can declining church attendance be reversed to generate transformation, revival, and growth through a community-based culture of hospitality? Can a stagnant church be revitalized through an intentional program that focuses on welcoming and accepting new guests and nonattending members?

It is generally known that church attendance in many parts of the world has decreased tremendously, and even among the majority of specific populations in countries that identify as Christian, most don't participate in regular church activities and programs. Many Seventh-day Adventist churches are experiencing plateau or decline, particularly in Western countries and among younger generations.

Many modern churches see themselves as warm and friendly communities for newcomers. This view comes mainly from their feelings about interacting with friends and acquaintances, as well as the superficial friendliness they often show to new visitors. They also believe that worship services and various programs create natural opportunities for connection and a sense of belonging.

Often a disconnect exists between what visitors perceive and the church's view of genuine hospitality. Although newcomers may be impressed by the worship, programs, or activities, they might still feel detached from the church's internal fellowship, which could lead to their stopping attendance altogether.

To reverse the trend, church growth specialists recommend creating authentic communities within the church and fostering a culture of intentional hospitality, which directly impacts both spiritual and numerical growth. That is why I invite you to consider several key components of the community-based hospitality approach.

DESIGNED TO CONNECT

Humanity was created to coexist harmoniously with divinity and one another. God made Adam and Eve to mirror the relationship among the persons of the Godhead, which are deeply interconnected through love, mutual support, and complementarity.

The biblical statement "It is not good that man should be alone" (Gen. 2:18) is often referenced in the context of marriage. Still, it can also serve as an example of the importance of all human interactions. "Two are better than one" (Eccl. 4:9) is another powerful reminder of the need for interconnectedness and mutual support.

God did not create us to live in isolation; that is a result of sin in our world. We are designed to connect and support one another, with each of us focusing on the growth and development of others.

Besides families and other essential support groups, the church was established by Jesus for the same purpose: to rebuild the concept of community for emotional and spiritual support for everyone. The apostles were trained and commanded to create an environment that promotes acceptance, altruism, and inclusion among all participants in church programs and activities.

Several biblical metaphors in the New Testament highlight the communal nature of the church. Phrases such as "the kingdom of God" (Mark 1:15; see also John 18:36), "the temple of God" (1 Cor. 3:16, 17), "the family of God" (see Matt. 12:49, 50), and "the body of Christ" (1 Cor. 12:27; see also Eph. 1:22) powerfully illustrate the idea of community among believers, emphasizing collective relationship with Jesus Christ over individualism.

The key elements of the New Testament spiritual gatherings were worship, fellowship, discipleship, compassionate service, and expanding God's kingdom. Togetherness in Christ was highly encouraged as an essential part of the Christian journey. Believers and guests prayed, read Scripture, sang hymns,

listened to sermons, praised God, participated in Communion, and were baptized as a collective act of worship.

A THEOLOGY OF WELCOME

The concept of hospitality is often linked to love, friendliness, and warmth toward others, which are essential to human relationships and are widely shown throughout the biblical narrative, from Genesis to Revelation. It reflects the core of God's nature as the supreme host. From the beginning God welcomed humanity into existence and established a special relationship with them, offering His loving grace and acceptance to everyone without discrimination.

In a spiritual sense, God acts as the host in worship, inviting everyone to join His kingdom on earth. Furthermore, Jesus

Often a disconnect exists between what visitors perceive and the church's view of genuine hospitality.

came to expand God's welcome and community within the framework of salvation and the redemption of the lost. This is exemplified in the statement "Come to me, all you who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest" (Matt. 11:28).

The church, as the household of God, is also called to be His ambassadors, practicing the theology of welcome indiscriminately and focusing on the emotional, physical, and spiritual needs of everyone. This is not optional, but the essence of Christianity, which is based on Jesus' promise that He "will draw all peoples to Myself" (John 12:32).

In other words, church hospitality is not merely a series of techniques or strategies aimed at attracting and retaining guests based on their perceived needs and shared interests. It is neither a spiritual gift nor an ability exclusive to a particular group of people. Instead, it reflects God's attributes and Jesus' primary mission to invite everyone into a covenant of love with Him.



We are designed to connect and support one another, with each of us focusing on the growth and development of others.

The Fellowship Factor

FELLOWSHIP AS A PREREQUISITE

The early church stressed the importance of fellowship as essential for discipleship and growth. Acts 2:42, referring to those who have been baptized and added to the church, states: “And they continued steadfastly in the apostles’ doctrine and fellowship, in the breaking of bread, and in prayers.” The new members were invited to join the church fellowship not just for social support but also to take part in the corporate worship and discipleship programs.

The New Testament clearly connects belonging to the body of Christ with the spiritual growth of each individual, all within the context of fellowship with God. The apostle John writes: “That you also may have fellowship with us; and truly our fellowship is with the Father and with His Son Jesus Christ” (1 John 1:3). The new believers were encouraged to walk with Jesus (Col. 2:6), “examine” themselves if they are “in the faith” (2 Cor. 13:5), be “crucified” with Jesus and let Him “live” in them (Gal. 2:20; Eph. 3:17-19), keep seeking the things “above” (Col. 3:1), and constantly “add” to their faith” (2 Peter 1:4-10).

AN AWARENESS CAMPAIGN

My Doctor of Ministry project focused on increasing awareness of community-based hospitality, and training was carried out at my church, which had 560 members in a city with a population of 100,000.

At the beginning of the process I assessed how church attendees perceived their sense of welcome and belonging. Later a dedicated action group composed of key stakeholders was formed to lead training, brainstorming, and review of the entire process. All departmental leaders responsible for welcoming and integration were encouraged to emphasize hospitality based on biblical principles and to support specific activities and programs in that area. Additionally, a series of sermons on community, sense of belonging, and hospitality were presented.

The post-implementation survey, which assessed both church members and guests, showed the effectiveness of the awareness campaign. The church was revitalized and became motivated to play its important role as part of God’s hospitality team for all attendees.

As a result, a couple who had recently begun attending the church were very impressed by the new welcoming environment, asked for Bible studies, and were soon baptized—highlighting the significance of a community-focused hospitality climate in personal and kingdom growth.

THREE KEYS

Any church seeking growth through community-based hospitality should follow three key steps.

First, encourage members to cultivate an intentional atmosphere of welcome before, during, and after worship, especially one that extends beyond the time and place of group gatherings. The spirit of community, belonging, and inclusiveness should be evident in every program and activity as an expression of God’s desire to connect and welcome everyone into a special relationship with Him and the church.

Second, train all leaders and ministries that have direct or indirect responsibilities for welcoming, community building, and integrating guests and new members. Different layers of welcome and hospitality need to be implemented, and every church activity or program should be assessed and adjusted accordingly.

Third, create opportunities for guests and members to foster stronger interactions built on love, acceptance, and mutual support. Whether in corporate worship services, small groups, or social events, innovative approaches should be used to enhance the sense of belonging and integration.

Unlike manipulative or superficial methods used to attract and retain new members, authentic hospitality is fundamental for the church’s spiritual and numerical growth. Both the sense of community and the ministry of welcome are rooted in God’s nature and are part of the Great Commission. God creates community through the Holy Spirit, and He invites the church to be His ambassador on earth. The ministry of hospitality is not part of discipleship or evangelism; understood from a biblical perspective, it is, in fact, a way of life, evangelism in its purest form. **✠**

Titus Naftanaila is president of the Wisconsin Conference of Seventh-day Adventists in the United States.

OUR GODLY HERITAGE

God's appointments and grants in our behalf are without limit. The throne of grace is itself the highest attraction because occupied by One who permits us to call Him Father. But God did not deem the principle of salvation complete while invested only with His own love. By His appointment He has placed at His altar an Advocate clothed with our nature. As our Intercessor, His office work is to introduce us to God as His sons and daughters. Christ intercedes in behalf of those who have received Him. To them He gives power, by virtue of His own merits, to become members of the royal family, children of the heavenly King . . .

No sooner does the child of God approach the mercy seat than he becomes the client of the great Advocate. At his first utterance of penitence and appeal for pardon Christ espouses his case and makes it His own, presenting the supplication before the Father as His own request. . . .

God desires His obedient children to claim His blessing and to come before Him with praise and thanksgiving. God is the Fountain of life and power. He can make the wilderness a fruitful field for the people that keep His commandments, for this is for the glory of His name. He has done for His chosen people that which should inspire every heart with thanksgiving, and it grieves Him that so little praise is offered. He desires to have a stronger expression from His people, showing that they know they have reason for joy and gladness.

Remembering and recounting the goodness of God

Ellen G. White

Keeping History Alive

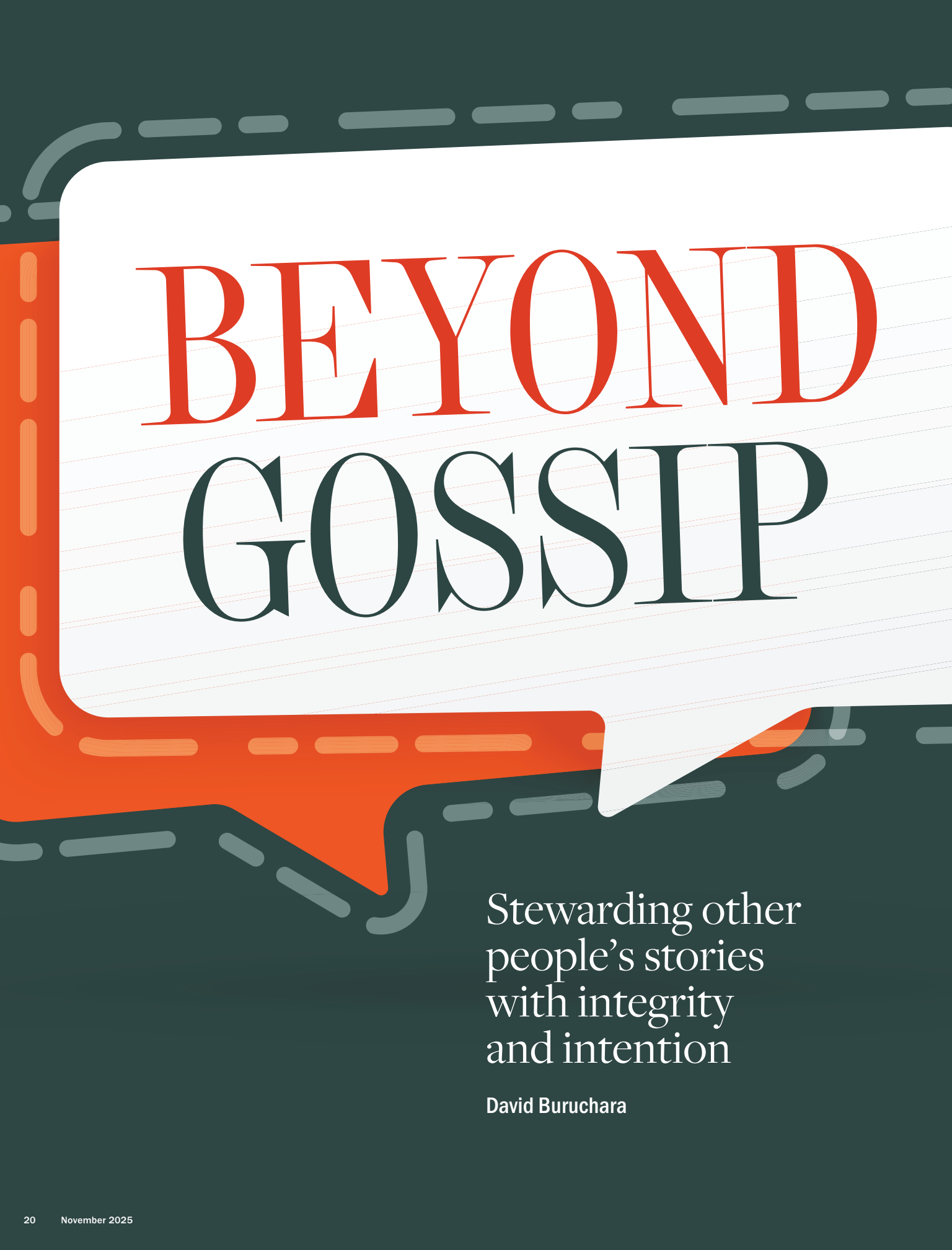
The dealings of God with His people should be often repeated. How frequently were the waymarks set up by the Lord in His dealings with ancient Israel! Lest they should forget the history of the past, He commanded Moses to frame these events into song, that parents might teach them to their children. They were to gather up memorials and to lay them up in sight. Special pains were taken to preserve them, that when the children should inquire concerning these things, the whole story might be repeated.

Thus the providential dealings and the marked goodness and mercy of God in His care and deliverance of His people were kept in mind. We are exhorted to call to "remembrance the former days, in which, after ye were illuminated, ye endured a great fight of afflictions." Hebrews 10:32. For His people in this generation the Lord has wrought as a wonder-working God. The past history of the cause of God needs to be often brought before the people,

young and old. We need often to recount God's goodness and to praise Him for His wonderful works.

While we are exhorted not to forsake the assembling of ourselves together, these assemblies are not to be merely for our own refreshing. We are to be inspired with greater zeal to impart the consolation we have received. It is our duty to be very jealous for the glory of God and to bring no evil report. . . . The whole person is privileged to bear a decided testimony in every line. In features, in temper, in words, in character, we are to witness that the service of God is good. Thus we proclaim that "the law of the Lord is perfect, converting the soul." Psalm 19:7. 

Seventh-day Adventists believe that **Ellen G. White** (1827-1915) exercised the biblical gift of prophecy during more than 70 years of public ministry. This excerpt is taken from *Testimonies for the Church*, volume 6, pages 364, 365.



BEYOND GOSSIP

Stewarding other
people's stories
with integrity
and intention

David Buruchara

We are storied creatures. Everyone has a story, and we're drawn to both telling and hearing them. Stories help us make sense of the world. We're especially drawn to the stories of others—their triumphs, mistakes, and turning points—connecting us to something bigger than ourselves. The Bible itself is a story: the story of God's love, revealed through the lives of real people through their highs and lows.

Books are stories. Movies are stories. Conversations are stories.

But there is a danger when the stories we share come at someone else's expense. When we trade another person's trust or reputation for our own moment of connection, we use their story as currency and spend it carelessly. Gossip doesn't just affect the person being spoken about. It also affects us, shaping our hearts in ways we may not realize (Prov. 18:8).

From casual rumors to spiritual-sounding "let's pray for so-and-so," gossip shows up everywhere: at work, school, church, and home. None of us wants to be gossiped about. But it's naive to think we can gossip about others without others ever gossiping about us. It's just as naive to believe that someone who gossips *with* you won't eventually gossip *about* you. Gossip is rarely a closed loop. But beyond the social risk, there's something deeper going on.

Gossip often fills the space where true vulnerability should be. When we're unwilling to open up about our own struggles or insecurities, we borrow someone else's vulnerability instead. It gives us the feeling of connection at someone else's cost, not our own. It's the same impulse that led Ham to

expose his father's shame to his brothers (Gen. 9:21-24). But like junk food, gossip is conversation that leaves us relationally undernourished—perhaps satisfying in the moment, but empty in the end.

It's Tempting

I'm often tempted by the cheap connection gossip offers, and I've found myself sharing things I shouldn't have. It's something I'm praying to recognize and resist. These three questions have been helping me be more intentional about how I can steward other people's stories with integrity and care:

When we trade another person's trust or reputation for our own moment of connection, we use their story as currency and spend it carelessly.

1. WOULD I BE OK SAYING THIS IF THE PERSON WERE IN THE ROOM? (MATT. 7:12)

If the words would sound different with them present, it is worth reconsidering. Scripture warns against taking advantage of someone's limitations—in this case, their absence—to do them harm (Lev. 19:14). This question can serve as a simple but powerful litmus test of both integrity and love.

2. AM I AVOIDING VULNERABILITY IN MYSELF? (MATT. 7:3-5)

Sometimes we choose to "spill the tea" about someone else because it feels safer than sharing from our own cup. But gossip is a way of avoiding true connection. That doesn't mean we need to be vulnerable with everyone. But it does mean we should ask: Am I talking about this person to avoid being real about myself?

3. WILL THIS CONVERSATION ENCOURAGE GROWTH WITHOUT SLANDERING SOMEONE'S CHARACTER? (EPH. 4:29)

I have a close friend who never gossips. He's a critical thinker (a Ph.D. graduate), yet he always assumes the best of people. He isn't toxically positive, and he doesn't avoid hard conversations. Yet he's never boring—his conversations are genuine, engaging, and meaningful. He once told me, "Whenever I speak, I pray it will either inform, inspire, or edify."

Paul urges the Ephesians to speak with intention, using words that build others up (Eph. 4:29). That doesn't mean

we ignore harmful behavior or stay silent when truth should be spoken. Even John warned about Diotrephes, naming his pride and slander as a threat to the community (3 John 9, 10). There's a time and place for speaking hard

truths. But even then our goal should be growth and protection, not faultfinding and character assassination.

Jesus is the opposite of everything gossip is. He is both honest and honoring with our stories, taking on our shame at *His own* expense, and making it safe for us to be vulnerable. Choosing real connection over counterfeit connection isn't easy at first. Like a healthy diet, it requires daily intentionality. But more fundamentally, it requires a change of appetite—one that only Jesus can create in us. He invites us to carry an easier yoke: conversations that are honest, life-giving, and rooted in love. **✠**

David Buruchara, M.Ed., LPC-R, is a couples therapist passionate about the intersection of mental health, relationships, and faith. He and his wife, Callie, reside in **Virginia, United States.**

GOD GETS THERE FIRST



No need
to sweat it

Shawn Boonstra

I startle awake, my pillow soaked with the sweat of disturbed sleep. I can feel my heartbeat in my ears, reminding me that all is not well. I glance at the alarm clock for the tenth or eleventh time this night. Three o'clock. In a few short hours the first burnt-orange hints of daylight will spill over the horizon, and all hope of sleep will be lost.

The evangelistic campaign has been going well; there are enough people in the audience that I will be spending the day making brief friendly visits on scores of doorsteps, assessing how well the message is taking root. And although I am the sort of introvert that does not particularly enjoy knocking on doors, it is not the thought of visitation that robs me of sleep. It is rather the knowledge of what I have promised to the churches for tonight: I will be making an altar call.

I flip my pillow to the dry side and grumble to myself about Charles Finney, the preacher who pioneered altar calls as we've come to experience them in Western Christianity. *Why*, I mutter, *did he have to put preachers under this kind of pressure?*

It started simply. Finney introduced the "anxious bench" near the front of the auditorium where convicted sinners could come to pray and receive counsel. It was a method of generating an immediate response to the gospel, and it has proved to be a powerful tool in leading congregations to make a decision for Christ. Others adopted the practice, and it persisted until it became the walk-to-the-front appeals (set to a mass choir singing "Just as I Am") that became the hallmark of Billy Graham crusades.

For people who are not particularly demonstrative—such as the Dutch, the tribe from which I hail—the whole affair can feel a little too emotionally vulnerable: *my* kind just doesn't walk to the front with every eye in the room tracking them. We make decisions quietly, privately.² And if *participating* in a public altar call is uncomfortable, the very thought of *conducting* one can be positively panic-inducing.

What if I'm not convincing enough? What if I end up becoming one of those poor slob who stands at the front for 20 or 30 minutes, pleading with an unresponsive room? "Is there just one person here? Who's going to take a stand tonight? Anybody?"

We've all seen—and pitied—that preacher. It's brutally awkward.

Don't get me wrong: I'm absolutely *not* opposed to altar calls. How could I be? If you craft them properly, with an understanding of how God operates in redeeming the lost, they work amazingly well. If you don't give your audience a chance to respond to the call of Christ, you may actually be training them *not* to respond to the overwhelming conviction that often accompanies the hearing of God's Word. You create the impression that it's OK to do nothing about what they're learning. People who sense the leading of the Spirit feel a tremendous urge to do something with their conviction, and providing a mechanism for response while that conviction is burning brightly . . . well, it's an incredibly good thing to do. And so even though it lies well outside my comfort zone, I do it.

The sweat-soaked pillow was many years ago now. I still get a little anxious about public speaking, but not like I did in the past. Where I used to feel physically ill, I now feel nervous tension, and a little nervousness is a good thing. If you aren't somewhat concerned about the outcome of what you're doing, you may not have fully comprehended what it is that you're participating in: you're partnering with heaven itself.

A Crucial Distinction

What mitigated my fear? Many years ago I realized something that set me free: *I cannot convert people.* Neither can you. There is no logical argument you can present that will convince a roomful of people to be interested in Christ. How do I know that for sure? The greatest evangelist of the Christian era convinced me. Writing to the troubled church of Corinth, Paul reminded them:

"Now we have received not the spirit of the world, but the Spirit who is from God, that we might understand the things freely given us by God. And we impart this in words not taught by human wisdom but taught by the Spirit, interpreting spiritual truths to those who are spiritual. The natural person does not accept the things of the Spirit of God, for they are folly to him, and he is not able to understand them because they are spiritually discerned" (1 Cor. 2:12-14, ESV).

If someone is not interested in spiritual matters, there isn't much I can do about it, apart from praying for that person. What *I can* do, however, is appeal to those who have already been brought under conviction by the Spirit. That's a completely different enterprise from trying to convince people. Ellen White provides a fascinating description of how the process works, in a passage that deals with the evangelistic training of the disciples:

"As Jesus ministered to the vast multitudes that gathered about Him, His disciples were in attendance, eager to do His bidding and to lighten His labor. They assisted in arranging the people, bringing the afflicted ones to the Saviour, and promoting the comfort of all. They watched for interested hearers, explained the Scriptures to them, and in various ways worked for their spiritual benefit. They taught what they had learned of Jesus, and were every day obtaining a rich experience."³

Don't miss the sequence of events, because it still works the same way 2,000 years later. Jesus is the minister, the one who drives the whole process—not me. He's the voice the crowd needs to hear, and that is still true today, in spite of the fact that Jesus is no longer physically present with us. In our time He speaks to hearts from

heaven's sanctuary through the voice of the Holy Spirit. Conviction is a product of His voice, not mine. Repentance is God's work, a gift to sinners (see Rom. 2:4).

While Jesus was speaking to hearts, the disciples were watching the faces of people, trying to discern interest. When they found it, they opened the Scriptures to those individuals in particular. It was—and still is—a winning formula, because when someone hears the voice of the Spirit to the heart, they will instinctively recognize that same voice in the Scriptures, a collection of documents He inspired the prophets to compose. The voice will feel familiar, right. The job of the disciples? To help people connect the dots and then invite them home.

That understanding—that God handles spiritual awakening, and that I cannot manufacture it—made me breathe a little easier when it came time for an appeal. You and I are not *making* converts—we are *finding* them. It is the greatest scavenger hunt in the universe, and it's a lot more fun than working under the misguided assumption that I am somehow in charge of the process. I am being asked to show up, to help put a human face on the message: when the disciples discovered interested hearers, they not only explained the Scriptures to them; they also “taught what they had learned of Jesus.”

You and I are
not *making*
converts—we are
finding them.

When people sense the Spirit pulling them toward Christ, and then find confirmation in the Book the Spirit composed, they will often next look at practicing believers with a new sense of hope. They're hoping it's true, and you become an exhibit of God's grace, an example of someone who has already made the decision. You are not required to be perfect at this point; nor are you expected to give a long discourse on the subject of salvation. Just a few words will suffice. Just tell them how much Jesus means to you, and why you trust Him.

Altar calls have become easier for me. I no longer speak as someone who is trying to generate conviction; instead I appeal to the interested, with the understanding that they are already moving in the right direction. God got to them *long* before I did.¹ My task is to appeal to the conviction that they already feel, or have felt for weeks, months, or years. I am to invite the convicted to *do* something about it. I'm issuing RSVP invitations on behalf of the real Host of the meeting.

We've been counseled to harvest only ripe fruit, and to be careful of it. “I began to gather the fruit near by,” Sister White reported from an important vision, “but very carefully, for fear of picking the green berries, which were so mingled with the ripe fruit that I could pick only one or two berries from a cluster.”² It doesn't mean that you don't keep green berries in your circle of influence; of course you do, so that you're present when they suddenly ripen.

Getting up front is still really uncomfortable, but I'll tell you one thing: when I realized how little I was actually in charge, my pillow started getting a whole lot drier. 

¹ Many refer to it as the “mourner's bench.”

² Another reason that home visitation is so important: many in the audience simply won't make a decision if it means exposing your emotions in front of a crowd of strangers.

³ Ellen G. White, *The Desire of Ages* (Mountain View, Calif.: Pacific Press Pub. Assn., 1898, 1940), p. 349.

⁴ Read the book of Acts and pay attention to the people brought into the church. They are not cold interests; God *always* gets to them first and awakens interest.

⁵ Ellen G. White, *Gospel Workers* (Washington, D.C.: Review and Herald Pub. Assn., 1915), p. 136.

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MAGNESIUM FOR SLEEP



Help or hype?

My 70-year-old mother struggles with insomnia. Will magnesium supplementation help her sleep better?

Good sleep is vital for health, and while insomnia has many causes and remedies, we will focus on your question about magnesium. Magnesium is a mineral the body needs for more than 300 processes, including nerve signaling, proper muscle control, and production of melatonin, the hormone critical for a good night's sleep. During the past few years scientists have been studying magnesium to see if it can help people sleep better. Some studies show it helps, but taking too much without guidance can be harmful.

Magnesium affects sleep by helping control certain brain chemicals (e.g., GABA), which calm the nervous system and make the body relax. It also helps keep melatonin at healthy levels. People who don't have enough magnesium in their bodies often struggle with poor sleep, waking up in the night, or with conditions such as restless leg syndrome.

Giving extra magnesium helps some people but not others. A study in 2012 tested giving magnesium to older adults who had insomnia. Those who took 500 milligrams of magnesium each day for eight weeks fell asleep faster, slept longer, spent more of their time in bed sleeping rather than being awake, and didn't wake up earlier than they wanted as often as before.¹ A 2021 review of many studies

showed that magnesium made a small but noticeable improvement in sleep quality, especially for older adults and people who had insomnia to begin with.² Still, scientists say more studies (and those of longer duration) are needed.

Taking extra magnesium seems most helpful for people who are low in it. This includes older adults, people with stomach or intestinal diseases such as Crohn's or celiac disease, people with type 2 diabetes, and those who don't eat enough magnesium-rich foods, such as leafy greens, nuts, and whole grains. For these people, fixing a deficiency can improve both sleep and overall health. Your mom may fall into one of these groups; her doctor will be able to tell better.

cles, and even irregular heartbeats. Magnesium can also lower the effect of some medicines or cause side effects when taken with water pills (diuretics), antibiotics, and bone medicines (bisphosphonates).

Anyone considering using magnesium for sleep should consult a doctor first. The best and safest way to get magnesium is still through a God-given, healthy diet full of foods that naturally contain it, such as black beans, kidney beans, spinach, tofu, nuts, oats, brown rice, and quinoa. These foods not only are rich in magnesium but also support overall health. **✝**

¹ Behnood Abbasi, Masud Kimiagar, et al., "The Effect of Magnesium Supplementation on Primary Insomnia in the Elderly: A Double-blind Placebo-controlled Clinical Trial," *Journal of Research in Medical Sciences* 17 (December 2012): 1161-1169.

² J. Mah and T. Pitre, "Oral Magnesium Supplementation for Insomnia in Older Adults: A Systematic Review and Meta-Analysis," *BMC Complementary Medicine and Therapies* 21 (2021): 125, <https://doi.org/10.1186/s12906-021-03297-z>.

People who don't have enough magnesium in their bodies often struggle with poor sleep, waking up in the night, or with conditions such as restless leg syndrome.

But be aware, taking too much without guidance can cause stomach upset, cramps, nausea, diarrhea, drug problems, or even serious illness. The safe upper limit for adults is 350 milligrams a day from supplements, unless a doctor says otherwise. For people with kidney problems, magnesium can build up to dangerous levels, causing low blood pressure, confusion, weak mus-

Zeno L. Charles-Marcel, a board-certified internist, is the director of Adventist Health Ministries at the General Conference. **Peter N. Landless**, a board-certified nuclear cardiologist and emeritus director of General Conference Adventist Health Ministries, is also a board-certified internist.



GUNS OR DOUGHNUTS

From
a life of
violence
to a
bakery

I grew up in a Seventh-day Adventist family in the Democratic Republic of the Congo. After a long period of violence and insecurity in my home area, I decided to join my older brother and become a soldier in the resistance army. Our family—my parents and younger siblings—were constantly under attack, so I became a soldier to protect them.”

Claude would rather talk about his work in the bakery than return to the fear-filled memories that overwhelmed him as a teenager. He had not wanted to become a warrior, but service with the resistance army seemed to offer some hope for a better life. Instead the insecurity worsened, and eventually his family fled to Rwanda, where they joined thousands of others as refugees.

“I stayed behind as a soldier with the resistance army, but by 2012 my older brother and I were tired of the army life, exhausted by everything we had gone through.

“It was during that time that I chose Jesus as my Savior. I realized life without Him could not satisfy me. I also remember praying to God when I was in frontline fighting. There was so much shooting and killing that I felt certain I was going to die. I remember I was missing my mom so much. I prayed that God would help me not die without seeing my mom, and He saved me.”

One of Claude’s worst memories during that time was calling his mother and hearing her sobbing. “All my children are going to die!” she cried. That was when Claude decided to leave the army and join his mother and younger brother in the refugee camp across the border in Rwanda. One look at his mother’s relieved face told him that he had made the right decision.



Dick
Duerksen

**“GOD HAS GIVEN
ME NEW AND
BETTER WAYS TO
BE HAPPY AND
PRODUCTIVE
WITH HIM.”**



There wasn't anything for a young soldier to do in the camp, but there was an elementary school that offered classes up through grade 9.

"I didn't believe I could go back to school and succeed, but I gave it a try," says Claude. "I returned to school in eighth grade. I worked hard, and things started to improve. After eighth grade I advanced to ninth grade and enjoyed learning everything I could."

Conditions in the camp were horrible. There were no jobs, little food, and no chance for Claude to fulfill his dreams of further education beyond ninth grade. For a while he was so discouraged that he decided the only thing for him to do was to return to the Congo and fight with the resistance army. His life, however, took a different turn when a team from Impact Hope arrived in the camp offering scholarships for upper secondary education.

Impacted by Hope

Hundreds of incredibly intelligent Seventh-day Adventist students like Claude have been mired in the refugee camps, eager to continue their education. But to attend the next grade in nearby towns, students have to walk miles there and back each day—journeys that are extremely dangerous, especially for the girls.

Stories of the need for a safe education reached several Adventist families abroad. They listened, visited the refugee camps in Rwanda, and devised a creative solution.

"There were several Adventist boarding academies in Rwanda, and all had empty beds," says Mindy Thygeson, president and cofounder of Impact Hope. "When we returned home, we began raising funds to provide scholarships for refugee youth to continue their education

“INSTEAD OF FIGHTING ON THE FRONT LINES IN THE CONGO, HE IS BECOMING A VERY SKILLED LEADER IN OUR BAKERY, MENTORING COUNTLESS OTHERS BEHIND HIM.”

in the safety of one of these boarding academies. Today we offer more than 800 academy scholarships for the best students in the refugee camps.”

“I was fortunate to be selected as one of the first candidates when Impact Hope was starting up,” Claude says. “Many young people in the camp wanted this opportunity, and I felt truly blessed to be among those chosen.”

Claude’s scholarship made it possible for him to attend Gahogo Adventist Academy in Muhanga district, Rwanda, and continue his education through twelfth grade.

“I’ll never forget the first time I saw the school campus,” Claude laughs. “As we were traveling to the Adventist academy, the driver pulled in at a beautiful place I thought must be a very special rest stop. When they told us this was our new school, I could hardly believe it. I was amazed that this truly was Gahogo Adventist Academy, the school I was going to attend.”

Claude studied hard and graduated from the academy in 2018. After graduation he was sponsored by Impact Hope to attend a one-year culinary arts vocational program operated by the Rwandan government. He immediately knew that he had found his dream!



Hands in the Dough

“Upon graduation from the culinary arts program, I got my first real job in the kitchen of a major Rwandan resort. Then Impact Hope contacted me again and invited me to become a culinary arts trainer at their new vocational training center: Center for Hope, right here in Rwanda.”

The Center for Hope offers six-month courses that lead to a vocational certificate that will provide students with a way to earn income for life. The four current career options are tailoring, hairdressing, culinary arts, and agriculture. You will find Claude, obviously, with his hands deep in the dough at the bakery.

“We were excited that Claude now leads our Center for Hope bakery,” says Brian Manley, director of Impact Hope. “Instead of fighting on the front lines in the Congo, he is becoming a very skilled leader in our bakery, mentoring countless others behind him.”

“Now that I am fully employed here in the bakery,” Claude says with a wide smile, “I am earning enough money so that I can pay my own way through the university courses and earn a full degree.”

A couple of Claude’s young students interrupt the conversation with a baking question, and he gives them a quick lesson on how to make sure the doughnuts (or mandazi, as they are called locally) are perfectly round balls. Then he continues: “I do not want just a little learning, but am eager to learn all I can, and as quickly as possible. When I think back to my days of desperation in the refugee camp, I thank God often that I did not just give up and go back to the army. Instead God has given me new and better ways to be happy and productive with Him.”

“Working with students reminds me of how Jesus walked with disciples. He taught them, corrected them, encouraged them. Most important, He loved them deeply. I see my role with students that way—to walk alongside them, guiding and planting seeds of faith that God will grow in His time.”

“By the way,” Claude asks, “may I offer you a mandazi?” 🍩



Dick Duerksen, a pastor and storyteller, lives in **Portland, Oregon, United States.**

MISSION UNITES PEOPLE

Erton Köhler

Mission unites people,” an elder told me joyfully after a sermon. He shared how his congregation had long been divided and inward-focused, uninterested in any broader mission initiative. When their division launched Hope Impact, an integrated evangelism program, they initially rejected it, convinced they already had better ways to reach their community.

But after two years of watching other churches participate, they reconsidered. Once they embraced the project, everything changed. Three years later the same elder testified that many of their internal conflicts had diminished—or disappeared—since they had wholeheartedly joined the church’s mission movement.

Mission unites. And unity is one of the greatest needs of the remnant church in today’s fragmented, polarized world. Ellen White reminds us: “The most convincing argument we can give to the world of Christ’s mission is to be found in perfect unity. . . . In proportion to our unity with Christ will be our power to save souls.”¹ She also counsels: “All the members are to draw together, that the church may become a spectacle to the world, to angels, and to men.”² And regarding the end-time movement, she is clear: “Together they are to carry the work forward to completion.”³

The early church at Pentecost shows this vital connection between mission and unity. Luke describes the 120 believers: “They were all with one accord in

one place” (Acts 2:1). United in spirit and purpose, they received the outpouring of the Holy Spirit. In a single day the church multiplied 25 times, with 3,000 baptisms (verse 41). Their secret was profound unity—hearts fully surrendered to mission, free from rivalry, criticism, or division.

“Unity is strength; disunion is weakness and defeat,”⁴ and mission is the best remedy to build that unity. As the British missionary David Livingstone once recommended: “The best remedy for a sick church is to put it on a missionary diet.”⁵

Through mission God unites His people. Join Him and His church in the great task of preaching the gospel. United, we are stronger, we go further, and we move faster toward the fulfillment of His mission. 

¹ Ellen G. White, *Our High Calling* (Washington, D.C.: Review and Herald Pub. Assn., 1961), p. 170.

² Ellen G. White, *Selected Messages* (Washington, D.C.: Review and Herald Pub. Assn., 1958, 1980), book 3, p. 16.

³ Ellen G. White, *The Acts of the Apostles* (Mountain View, Calif.: Pacific Press Pub. Assn., 1911), p. 276.

⁴ Ellen G. White, *Counsels on Health* (Mountain View, Calif.: Pacific Press Pub. Assn., 1923), p. 518.

⁵ David Livingstone, quoted in multiple collections of missionary writings.

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THE BOY WHO SAVED HIS CHURCH

One boy's windy-day hobby turned into a mission that changed his church forever.

Ten-year-old Wellington loved flying kites in Brazil. His family lived in the busy city of Mauá, and on windy days Wellington could hardly wait to get outside.

He grabbed his favorite kite—a bright one that would be easily seen—and hurried out the door. Everyone knows you cannot fly a kite in a house. That would be silly. The ceiling would stop it in about three seconds!

He walked down the street, scanning the area. A good kite flier always looks for an open space without nearby houses, trees, or power lines. Nothing was worse than watching your kite get stuck in a tree or tangled in wires. A big grassy park was the perfect spot, but sometimes Wellington flew his kite right there in the wide street in front of his house.

The real challenge was getting the kite to climb into the sky. But Wellington was good at it. Standing with his

back to the wind, he held the kite high, waited for the right gust, and let the string out quickly. If the wind was strong enough, the kite would leap upward, dancing and twisting before catching the breeze.

Once it was up, Wellington had a special trick—he let the kite drift far away from him, then pulled it back toward him, over and over. Each time, the kite climbed a little higher, until it was just a small, colorful dot against the wide blue sky. Then he'd lean back and watch it float and dip, free and happy.

One day, during school vacation, Wellington was in the street flying his kite when he saw a man and a woman walking toward him. They smiled warmly. "We're the directors of a Pathfinder club at a Seventh-day Adventist church nearby," the man said. "Would you like to join?" the woman added. "We do all kinds of fun activities—and we learn about Jesus from the Bible."



Pathfinders? Wellington had never heard of such a thing. His family was Christian, but they weren't Adventists. Still, the idea made him curious. Fun activities and learning more about Jesus sounded . . . well . . . even better than flying a kite.

With his parents' permission Wellington joined the Pathfinder club when school started again. He learned to camp, cook over a fire, march in formation, and earn colorful honor patches for his sash. But the best part was learning about Jesus in a way he had never had before.

After a while he began studying the Bible regularly with someone from the church. Week after week, month after month, he discovered more about God's love. Three years later, when Wellington was 13, he made the most important choice of his life—he decided to give his heart fully to Jesus and be baptized. His whole family came to the church to see it. Wellington felt as if his heart was soaring higher than any kite he had ever flown.

From then on, he worshipped at the church every Sabbath. The members became like a second family to him. But

over time he began to notice something troubling—some of the other Pathfinders had stopped coming. Then more stopped. Soon there were hardly any young people in Sabbath School. Even the number of older members had dwindled.

Wellington worried. *What if the church closed?* He prayed earnestly: "Please, God, do a miracle."

FUN ACTIVITIES AND LEARNING MORE ABOUT JESUS SOUNDED BETTER THAN FLYING A KITE.

As he prayed, another thought came to him—maybe he could be part of that miracle. He remembered how the Pathfinder leaders had come to *him* when he was just a boy in the street. Now it was his turn to go to others.

The next Sabbath morning Wellington and a friend walked to the home of a boy who hadn't been to church in a long time. They knocked on the door. "Good morning!" Wellington said cheerfully. "We'd like to have Sabbath School with you in your home today."

The boy smiled and let them in. The next Sabbath they went to another home. Week after week they kept visiting. After three months five boys and girls had returned to church. After six months 22 young people were coming to Sabbath School every week!

Wellington was overjoyed. God had saved his church—and even more important, He was saving hearts. Wellington felt like a kite, lifted high by God's hand. "I praise God, who held my hand," Wellington says. "Today I can't live without Him."

Have you ever felt that you are too young to do something for God? Wellington's story reminds us that God can use anyone—no matter their age—to bring others to Him. What began with a simple kite on a windy day became the start of a journey that changed not only Wellington's life but the lives of many young people in his church. When we say yes to God's call, He can help us soar higher than we could ever imagine! **✝**

This story has been adapted from the *Children's Mission Quarterly*, Third Quarter, 2022. It has been used with permission.

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